He was taken aback.

‘Test the machine, eh?’

Soon he regained his posture. ‘Why not, tell me how do you want to test this machine?’

‘You said the machine would catch a lie, but it wouldn’t catch a truth, right?

‘Right.’

‘OK, I am going to write five names on different pieces of paper. I will tell you the five names and keep one of the pieces with me.’

Lahari was amused now; I continued. ‘You have to call the names, one by one, and ask me if the piece of paper in my hand has the name. For all the five names I would say ‘no’, which means I have said four truths and a lie. I hope your machine will catch that one lie, and only that one lie.’

I was fighting tears as I wrote the names Meena (my wife), Sankar (son), Geetha (daughter), Ayyappa (the lord) and Nambi. But as Dr Lahari started the trial, I was enjoying it.

‘Mr Nambi Narayanan, does the name on the paper in your hand read Meena?’

‘No.’

‘Is it Sankar?’

‘No.’

A pause.

‘Geetha?’

‘No.’

A longer pause.

‘Ayyappa?’

‘No.’

‘Nambi?’

‘No.’

Dr Lahari showed no change in his expression through the exercise. Now he told me which one of my ‘no’ was a lie. To remove any doubt in my mind about it not being a guessing game, he showed me how the amplitude of the line graph on the screen had jumped when I said ‘no’ when